

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

We have no
choice about the
past.

If we have no choice
about A, and no
choice about the
connection between
A and B, then we
have no choice about
B.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the Foreknowledge
Argument?

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false.

That is good for the defender of free will.

But here is a challenge for someone who tries to get around the foreknowledge argument by adopting the view that God is outside of time. It looks like we could reformulate the relevant premises as follows:

- 1'. We have no choice about events which are **outside of time**.
- 2'. **Outside of time**, God had knowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

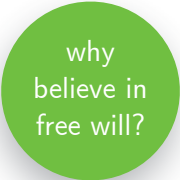
And from there the argument can just go on as before. So the worry is that Aquinas' view gives us one way to block the Foreknowledge Argument, but that the argument can be easily reformulated so as to avoid the objection.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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3. We have not checked the fact that

God knows that in the future I will

performancetainaction.(1,2)

2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of

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3 We have not heard that God



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So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

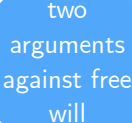
So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a



two
arguments
against free
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is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

with reference to the being of truth about

our future actions.

God only shows up in premises (2) and

replace reference to God's foreknowledge





3 We have not the fact that

God knows that in the future I will

2* In the past, there were truths about

acaioid.

1. We have no direct facts.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

perform a certain action (1,2)

then we have the choice about q.

all of our activities.

0 We have achieved what we

that if it is true that I will perform

5* We have noticed that the fact

some action, then I will prefer that

(3, 4, 5)

will perform various actions.

The fatalist argument

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